



CFA Institute®

AI Investment Challenge

Frequently Asked Questions
2025 – 2026 Season

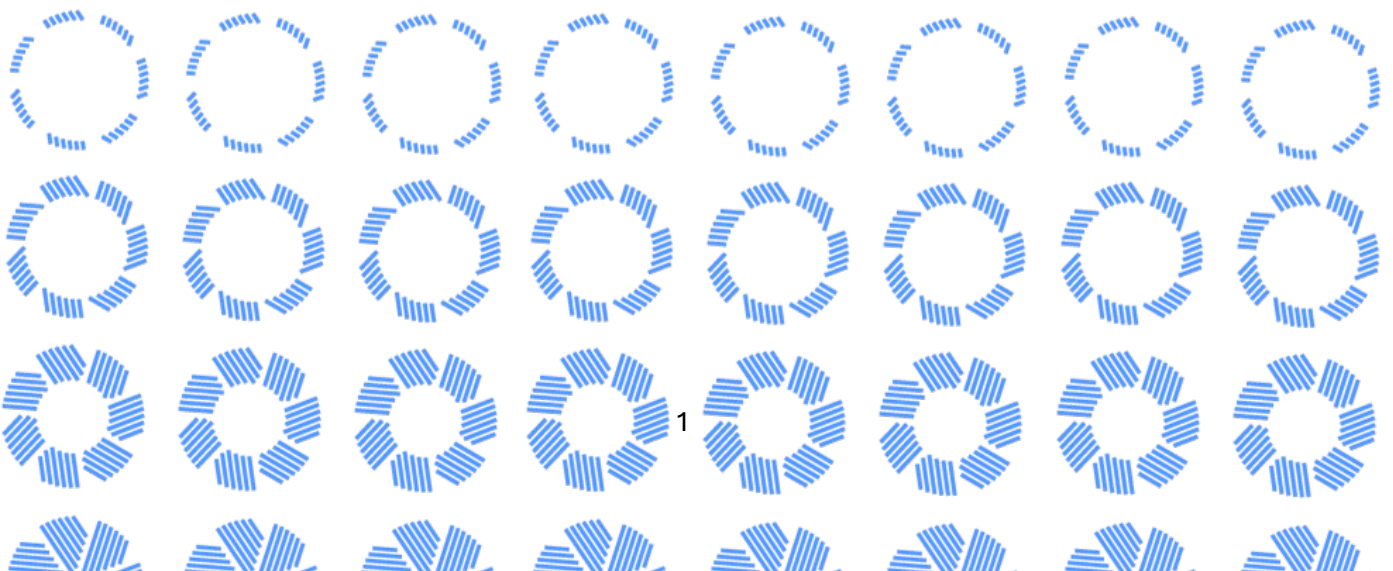


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Eligibility & Teams

Q: Can team members be from different universities?

A: No, all team members must be enrolled at the same university.

Q: Can a university have more than one team?

A: Yes, registrations will take place on a first-come, first-served basis with a single university being able to register as many teams as possible until all slots are filled.

Q: Can graduate and undergraduate students be on the same team?

A: Yes, teams may include both graduate and undergraduate students.

Q: Is there an age limit or minimum year requirement?

A: There is no age limit or minimum year requirement. All currently enrolled bachelor and master university students are eligible to participate.

Q: Can I be on multiple teams?

A: No, each participant may only be a member of one team.

Q: Are PhD students allowed to compete?

A: No, those that are currently enrolled or have completed a PhD are not allowed to compete.

Q: What if I'm a CFA Level I/II/III candidate – am I still eligible?

A: Yes, CFA candidates are eligible to participate. Only current CFA charterholders are ineligible to compete.

Q: What if my university doesn't have a finance or CS program – can I still participate?

A: Yes, students from any academic program may participate. The competition welcomes diverse perspectives and interdisciplinary teams.

Q: What if a team member drops out?

A: Team members can be replaced up to one week before the competition. However, teams must maintain at least three members to remain eligible.

Registration & Logistics

Q: How do I register my team?

A: Registration opens after the launch webinar on February 11th. Follow the registration page instructions for details. Registration closes February 20th.

Q: What are the key deadlines for each round?

A: See the timeline below:

- February 11: Launch webinar
- February 11–20: Registration open (deadline: February 20)
- March 1–13: Stage 1 concept submission (deadline: March 13)
- March 26 – April 9: Stage 2 mentorship and solution development (deadline: April 9)
- Late April (TBC): Final presentations

Q: Are late submissions accepted?

A: For stage 1 late submissions will not be accepted. For stage 2 partial submissions with route for completion will be accepted but keep in mind this may affect your score.

Q: Is there a registration fee?

A: No, there is no registration fee. Participation in the AI Investment Challenge is free.

Q: Who is the local host for my region, and how do I contact them?

A: This competition is hosted by CFA Institute in collaboration with CFA Society UK. Contact details are provided in the Official Rules.

Q: Will there be virtual/remote participation options, or is everything in-person?

A: Stages 1 and 2 are conducted remotely. Only the final presentations in late April are in-person.

Stage 1 – Concept Submission

Q: Do I need working code for Stage 1?

A: No. Stage 1 is a concept submission only. You will build the working prototype in Stage 2.

Q: What makes a strong concept submission?

A: A clear problem definition, a feasible solution approach, demonstrated understanding of investment industry impact, and thoughtful ethical considerations.

Q: What format should the 2–4 page submission be in?

A: Submissions should be in Word (.docx) or PDF format. Use the submission template provided in Appendix A.

Q: Is there a word count limit or specific formatting requirements?

A: Submissions should be 2–4 pages. Use the provided template in Appendix A for guidance on structure and content expectations.

Q: Can we include diagrams, flowcharts, or mock-ups in the concept submission?

A: Yes, diagrams and flowcharts are encouraged to illustrate your solution. These count toward the 2–4 page limit.

Stage 2 – Prototype Development

Q: What programming languages can I use?

A: Common languages such as Python, R, JavaScript/Typescript are acceptable. If you plan to use a different language, contact the host for approval.

Q: Can we use proprietary/closed-source AI APIs (like OpenAI, Anthropic)?

A: Yes, you may use closed-source APIs from OpenAI, Anthropic, or Google. Document what you use and explain why it fits your solution.

Q: Can I use open-source libraries?

A: Yes, with proper attribution. See Rule 1.2 on plagiarism and Rule 1.3 on intellectual property rights in the Official Rules.

Q: What counts as "verifiable, working code"?

A: Your solution must produce functional, testable output — not a conceptual demo or mock-up. Partially completed code is acceptable if there is a clear path to completion.

Q: Do we need to deploy our solution, or is a GitHub repo sufficient?

A: For tools or web apps, the solution should be hosted via GitHub Pages or an equivalent public deployment. You must provide links to both the front-end and the source code repository. For non-web solutions, a GitHub repository with clear setup instructions is sufficient.

Q: What if our solution requires paid APIs or cloud compute — who covers costs?

A: Teams are responsible for any costs associated with their solution. Google Gemini offers a free tier with no credit card required. Anthropic and OpenAI have researcher and university programs that your institution may already be involved in. We recommend speaking with your university about API credits or cloud computing resources that may be available to students.

Q: What if our solution requires real-time data feeds we can't afford?

A: All data must be publicly available to ensure reproducibility. If real-time feeds are cost-prohibitive, consider using historical data, free data sources, or designing your solution to work with delayed/sample data that demonstrates the concept.

Q: Is there a specific timeline for Stage 2 development?

A: Stage 2 runs from March 26 to April 9. You will have approximately two weeks to develop your working solution with mentor support.

Q: Does my prototype need a user interface?

A: A user interface is not required, but your solution must produce interpretable outputs, visualizations, or analytical results.

Q: What format should the Stage 2 submission be in?

A: Use the Stage 2 submission template provided in Appendix B, along with your code repository and deployment links.

Mentorship

Q: What can my mentor help with?

A: Mentors provide industry guidance, feedback on your approach, and help refine your solution. They cannot write code for you or do your work.

Q: How often will we meet with our mentor? What's the expected time commitment?

A: Mentors will provide 2-3 hours of guidance over the 2-week Stage 2 development period. Meeting frequency is flexible and arranged between your team and mentor based on your needs.

Q: How are mentors assigned to teams?

A: Mentors are randomly assigned by the host.

Q: Can we contact our mentor outside scheduled sessions?

A: This is up to your mentor. Discuss communication preferences and availability when you first connect.

Stage 3 – Final Presentation

Q: How long are the final presentations?

A: Presentations are 10 minutes, followed by 5 minutes of Q&A with the judges.



Q: Will presentations be in-person or virtual?

A: Final presentations are in-person in late April. The top 5 teams will present live to a panel of judges.

Q: Who are the judges?

A: Judges are industry experts, including CFA charterholders and investment professionals. Specific judges will be announced closer to the final presentations.

Q: Can we do a live demo, or is it slides only?

A: Live demos are permitted, but keep in mind you only have 10 minutes and technical difficulties will count against your time.

AI Tools & Code

Q: Can I use generative AI (ChatGPT, Claude, Copilot) to help write code?

A: Yes, but you must understand and be able to explain the code in your solution. You may be asked to explain it in your presentation. Document any significant AI assistance used.

Q: What counts as plagiarism for code?

A: Using others' code without attribution. Open-source code with proper licensing and citation is acceptable.

Data & Technical

Q: Can I use publicly available financial datasets?

A: Yes, with proper citation and compliance with the dataset's terms of use.

Q: Can I use proprietary data from my employer?

A: No, all data must be open access to ensure reproducibility.

Q: Are there any restricted data types we cannot use?

A: You cannot use proprietary data from your employer or any non-public data. All data must be publicly available to ensure reproducibility.

Q: Can we use synthetic/simulated data if real data isn't available?

A: Yes, synthetic or simulated data is acceptable. Document how the data was generated and ensure your approach could work with real data.

Q: What if our solution involves trading signals — are there compliance concerns?

A: There are no compliance restrictions on developing trading signals. Just be aware that winning solutions will be made public when showcased on RPC Labs, a public CFA Institute GitHub repository.

Q: Do we need to worry about model explainability requirements?

A: While not strictly required, explainability strengthens your solution. Judges will evaluate how well you can explain your model's outputs and decision-making process during the presentation.

Intellectual Property

Q: Who owns the intellectual property for solutions developed during the competition?

A: Teams retain full ownership of their solutions. By participating, teams grant CFA Institute and the Host a non-exclusive license to showcase submissions on CFA Institute platforms (such as public GitHub pages or competition dashboards) for educational and promotional purposes. CFA Institute will not commercialize team solutions. All code must be released under the MIT License.

Q: What is the MIT License?

A: The MIT License is a simple, permissive open-source license that allows anyone to use, modify, and distribute your code freely while you retain copyright ownership. It's one of the most widely used open-source licenses and ensures your solution can benefit the broader investment community.

Q: If I use MIT License, can a company just take my solution and commercialize it?

A: The MIT License is the standard open-source license used in this competition. By participating, you are open-sourcing your solution for the broader investment community's benefit. The license allows anyone to use, modify, and distribute your code, but you retain copyright ownership.

Q: Can I continue developing my solution after the competition for commercial purposes?

A: Yes, you retain full ownership of your solution. You can continue developing it for any purpose, including commercial use.

Recognition

Q: Can I put this on my resume or LinkedIn?

A: Yes. Winners will receive a digital certificate from CFA Institute.



Responsible AI

Q: What ethical considerations should I address in my submission?

A: Consider how your solution handles: data privacy (is personal or sensitive data involved?), bias (could your model produce unfair or skewed outputs?), transparency (can users understand how decisions are made?), and reliability (what happens if the model is wrong?). You don't need to solve every issue — but you should demonstrate awareness of potential risks and explain how you plan to mitigate them.

Q: Do I need to follow a specific responsible AI framework?

A: No specific framework is required. Focus on identifying risks relevant to your solution — such as data bias, lack of explainability, or potential for misuse — and explain how you plan to address them. Your Stage 1 ethical considerations will be used as the baseline for evaluating your final solution.

Appendix A: Stage 1 Concept Submission Template

(Use this template for your Stage 1 submission. Submissions should be 2–4 pages in Word (.docx) or PDF format.)

Team Information

Team Name:

University:

Team Members (names and roles):

Primary Contact Email:

Date:

1. Problem Definition

Describe the real-world investment challenge or inefficiency you are addressing and why it matters.

[Approximately 300–500 words]

2. Solution Overview

Explain how your AI-based approach works, conceptually or technically. Include the models, data sources, or workflow you intend to implement.

[Approximately 400–600 words]

3. Planned Implementation

Outline the technical stack, tools, and approach you will use to build and verify your solution in later stages.

[Approximately 300–400 words]

4. Impact Assessment

Highlight how your solution could improve performance, efficiency, or insight in the investment process.

[Approximately 200–400 words]

5. Ethical Considerations

Discuss any data, model, or bias considerations and how you plan to handle them responsibly.

Note: Your final solution will be evaluated against these commitments.



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[Approximately 200–300 words]



Appendix B: Stage 2 Solution Submission Template

(Use this template for your Stage 2 technical explanation (2–4 pages). Submit alongside your functional code repository. Word counts are approximate guidelines, not strict limits — prioritize clarity and completeness.)

Team Information

Team Name:

University:

Date:

1. Executive Summary

Provide a brief summary of your working solution in 4 bullet points. Include any significant changes from your Stage 1 concept.

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-
-
-

[4 bullet points for a total of approximately 100–200 words]

2. Repository & Deployment Links

GitHub Repository URL:

Live Demo URL (if applicable):

Note: Repository must be public or provide access to judges. Code must be released under MIT License.

3. Architectural Design & Workflow

Describe the technical architecture of your solution, including key components and how they interact. Explain your data pipeline and workflow from input to output.

[Approximately 200–400 words]



4. Data Sources

List all data sources used with proper citations. All data must be publicly available. Describe any data preprocessing steps.

[Approximately 150–250 words]

5. Discussion of Results

Present and discuss your solution's outputs or analytical results. Include relevant metrics, visualizations, examples demonstrating your solution's effectiveness and any relevant shortcomings that need attention.

[Approximately 300–500 words]

6. Model Interpretability & AI Usage

Explain how your model's outputs can be interpreted and understood. Document all AI tools, pre-trained models, and APIs used and explain their role in your solution.

[Approximately 200–300 words]